QNN RESEARCH · CHAINLINK · RESEARCH #07

The Price of Trust

The best business in crypto — and why the token doesn't feel it

$36T
value of transactions enabled

−82%
LINK from its 2021 high

6.05M
LINK bought by the Reserve

~19M
LINK unlocked every quarter

A full Chainlink breakdown in plain words: what an oracle is, CCIP and the Reserve, banks and DTCC, the exodus from LayerZero, unlocks to Binance, staking, ETFs and our own math: when buybacks overtake sales. 29 slides.

DATA AS OF NOV 14, 2026 · NOT FINANCIAL ADVICE

INSIDE

Swift, DTCC and Schwab, a 6M LINK Reserve, 19M unlocks per quarter, the break-even point, the 2029 "cliff", incidents and competitors

Key points in a minute

PRICE

$9.71

LINK on Nov 14, 2026. High: $52.70 (2021), about −82%

MARKET CAP

$7.44B

#17 by market cap. 766.85M of 1B in circulation

NETWORK FLOW

$36T

TVE — value of transactions enabled by Chainlink

MAIN MINUS

19M

LINK unlocked every quarter, most of it goes to Binance

BUYBACK

6.05M

LINK in the Chainlink Reserve — bought with revenue, never sold

MARKET SHARE

$35.8B

TVS: DeFi money that relies on Chainlink oracles. #1 by a wide margin

IN SHORT The network has never been bigger, yet the token sits near its lows. This whole research is about that gap

Sources: CoinGecko, Chainlink Quarterly Review Q3 2026, DefiLlama, ChainCatcher

What could lift the price, and what could sink it

▲ Could lift

- **Institutions:** Swift, DTCC, J.P. Morgan, Schwab — in production, not pilots
- **Reserve:** revenue turns into LINK that is never sold, and the pace is rising
- **CCIP:** $4B+ moved over from LayerZero after the Kelp DAO hack
- **The ~2029 cliff:** unallocated tokens run out, selling pressure disappears

▼ Could sink

- **Unlocks:** ~76M LINK a year — about 10% of circulating supply
- **Small revenue:** ≈$59M a year onchain vs a $7.4B market cap
- **Loose link to the token:** banks pay in dollars, not LINK
- **Competitors:** Pyth and RedStone take perps and restaking

IN SHORT The upside is in clients and product. The downside is in token design and in who is selling

Sources: Chainlink, DefiLlama, ChainCatcher, KuCoin

What an oracle is and how Chainlink works

1

Data sources

Exchanges, price aggregators, banks, rating agencies

S&P, Moody's
data already onchain

→

2

Nodes

Independent operators collect the data and sign it

4.125M
LINK of node stake

→

3

Aggregation

Nodes compare answers and publish a single final value

1 price
instead of dozens of sources

→

4

Smart contract

Aave, a bank or an exchange gets the price and settles

$35.8B
depends on this data

IN SHORT Blockchains can't see the outside world. Chainlink is the "eyes" of smart contracts: prices, rates, bank data

Chainlink applies the same "many independent nodes" principle to cross-chain transfers (CCIP) and compute (CRE). Sources: Chainlink docs, DefiLlama

Products: six services, one network

DATA

Data Feeds and Streams

Asset prices. Streams — sub-second latency, for perps and Polymarket

CROSS-CHAIN

CCIP

Token and message transfers between chains. Version 2.0 launched Sep 28, 2026

COMPUTE

CRE

An environment where a bank assembles a multi-step workflow: Swift, DTCC, Bottomline

COMPLIANCE

ACE

Checks: identity, sanctions, who is allowed to buy an asset

TRANSPARENCY

Proof of Reserve

Onchain proof that a token is backed by real reserves

REVENUE

SVR

Returns liquidation profits to protocols: $24.4M+ so far

IN SHORT Chainlink stopped being “just an oracle” long ago. It is a service stack that banks build tokenization on

New in 2026: Fulcrum (cross-chain repo), CustodySync (custodian + DeFi loans), Chainlink 24/7 (weekend stock prices). Sources: Chainlink Q3 2026, Link:NYC

Team: who builds Chainlink



Sergey Nazarov

Co-founder, the face of the project

X: @SergeyNazarov ↗

Born in the USSR, studied at NYU (philosophy and management). Before Chainlink — SmartContract.com. In 2026 spoke at the White House, sits on a CFTC advisory committee



Steve Ellis

Co-founder, CTO

Technical co-founder. Built CryptaMail and SmartContract.com with Nazarov, co-author of the 2017 white paper



Ari Juels

Chief Scientist

Professor at Cornell Tech, IC3 co-director, former chief scientist of RSA Labs. Co-author of the Chainlink and Chainlink 2.0 white papers



Johann Eid

Chief Business Officer

Leads sales and partnerships: banks, exchanges, governments. In 2025 said banks, governments and institutions will inevitably move onchain



Kemal El Moujahid

Chief Product Officer

Previously led product for TensorFlow at Google, and before that launched the Messenger platform at Meta

Chainlink Labs

Development company

X: @chainlink ↗

600+ employees. Core development, sales and the token treasury. The protocol formally belongs to the Chainlink Foundation

IN SHORT Strength: a public team with access to regulators. Weakness: everything rests on one company

The team has public faces and profiles, but the unallocated token wallets and unlock decisions also sit with one company

Timeline: from ICO to Swift

2017
ICO and white paper
Nazarov, Ellis, Juels

2019
Mainnet
First price feeds

MAY 2021
High of $52.70
Peak of the DeFi boom

2023
CCIP and staking v0.2
45M LINK pool

AUG 2025
Chainlink Reserve
Buybacks from revenue

DEC 2025
First LINK ETF
Grayscale GLNK

MAY 2026
LayerZero exodus
Kraken, Lombard → CCIP

SEP–OCT 2026
CCIP 2.0, Swift
Sibos and Link:NYC

IN SHORT Every cycle Chainlink adds a new product. The price moves separately from the news

Sources: Wikipedia, Chainlink, The Block, Cointelegraph

The network in numbers

FLOW

$36T

TVE — value of transactions enabled by Chainlink. In December 2025 it was $27.5T

CCIP

$85B

value of tokens secured by CCIP in Q3 2026

REACH

1,040+

EVM-to-EVM lanes in CCIP 2.0

BITCOIN

70%+

of wrapped BTC now runs on Chainlink: BitGo moved $7.7B of WBTC

MIGRATIONS

$15B+

of tokens migrated to CCIP in 2026

REVENUE

$24.4M+

returned to protocols from liquidations by SVR

IN SHORT On every usage metric Chainlink leads. The question isn't demand for the network, it's demand for the token

Sources: Chainlink Q3 2026, FXStreet

Oracle market share: a TVS monopoly



IN SHORT Chainlink secures more money than the next five oracles combined

TVS — how much DeFi money depends on an oracle's prices. Pyth often beats Chainlink on perp trading volume — that metric tells a different story. Source: DefiLlama

Banks and institutions: who is already live

Swift	**Swift ledger**	A solution connecting banks to Swift's blockchain ledger via CRE (Sibos, Sep 29). In November Swift joined the ERC-3643 Association
DTCC	**US securities**	First production trades of tokenized securities with 30+ institutions. 24/7 collateral go-live expected in Q4 2026
J.P. Morgan	**Collateral at CME**	A tokenized stock was posted as collateral to CME in a live DTCC trade
Charles Schwab	**Buying LINK**	Adding LINK to Schwab Crypto: 40M brokerage accounts
Bottomline	**Payments**	Cross-border payments for 600+ bank customers
Asia	**Hanwha, LG CNS, HKGX**	Hanwha's tokenization platform, a Bank of Korea project (LG CNS), Hong Kong gold on CCIP

IN SHORT These aren't pilots or MOUs: DTCC and J.P. Morgan have already run real transactions through Chainlink

Also: Moody's, S&P Global Ratings, Coinbase (oracle for tokenized stocks on Base), Circle Arc. Sources: Chainlink Q3 2026, Link:NYC, newsroom

The LayerZero exodus: how CCIP won on a rival's hack

1

Kelp DAO hack

April 2026: 116,500 rsETH stolen from a LayerZero-powered bridge

$292M
one of the year's largest hacks

→

2

Risk review

Protocols check who secures their cross-chain transfers

5+
major projects leave

→

3

Move to CCIP

Kelp, Solv, Re, Lombard, Lido; Kraken — exclusively for kBTC

$4B+
moved from LayerZero

→

4

Effect

LayerZero's ZRO −26% in a month, record migrations to CCIP

$15B+
to CCIP in 2026

IN SHORT Someone else's hack became CCIP's best ad: the market chose not the cheapest bridge, but the most "boring" one

LayerZero still leads by message count (~75%), but for large assets the market votes for CCIP. Sources: KuCoin, Cointelegraph, The Block

Tokenomics: 1 billion and not a coin more

TOTAL

1B

Fixed supply. No mining, no block rewards, no extra minting

CIRCULATING

766.85M

76.7% of total supply

REMAINING

233M

In Chainlink Labs “Non-circulating supply” wallets

UNLOCK

~19M

LINK per quarter. ≈76M a year — about 10% of circulating supply

STAKING

45M

v0.2 pool cap. Rewards are paid from unlocks

ETF

16.65M

LINK held by GLNK and CLNK at end of Q3

IN SHORT No new coins are minted. But a quarter of supply is still with the team, and it reaches the market every quarter

Sources: CoinGecko, ChainCatcher, Chainlink Staking, Chainlink Q3 2026

Unlocks: where the team's tokens go

Mar 15, 2025	19M LINK	14.875M to Binance, 4.125M to a multisig (≈$262M at that day's price)
Apr 4, 2026	~19M LINK	14.375M to Binance, 4.625M to multisig 0xD50...8Af. LINK around $8.63
Jun 20, 2026	21M LINK	From four addresses, ≈$166M. Same pattern: Binance + staking multisig
Typical	10–20M	Once a quarter. Funds development, node payments and staker rewards

IN SHORT Unlocks follow a schedule with no surprises. But nearly three quarters go straight to an exchange every time

To track: "Chainlink: Non-circulating Supply" addresses on Etherscan and Arkham; transfers to Binance usually show up within hours. Sources: ChainCatcher, MEXC, The CC Press, CMC

Staking v0.2: how it works

1. **45M LINK pool**
   Community — 40.875M, 1 to 15,000 LINK per address. Nodes — 4.125M, 1,000 to 75,000 LINK. Pool slots filled within hours

2. **Yield ≈4.32% a year**
   Base rate is 4.5%, but 4% of rewards go to nodes as payment for community “delegation”

3. **Slashing only for nodes**
   If the ETH/USD feed breaks, nodes lose stake. Whoever raises a valid alert first gets 7,000 LINK

4. **Exit — 28 days**
   Unbonding: you can’t withdraw instantly. Expanding staking to CCIP is promised but not yet done

IN SHORT Staking secures the network but creates no new demand: rewards come from the same unlocks

Sources: Chainlink Staking, Chainlink blog on v0.2, The Block

Chainlink Reserve: how revenue becomes LINK

1

Client pays

A bank in dollars, a protocol in stablecoins or ETH. Paying in LINK isn't required

Fiat
or any token

→

2

Payment Abstraction

An onchain mechanism automatically converts the payment into LINK

SVR
50% of fees go here

→

3

Reserve

The bought LINK goes into the reserve and is not sold

6.05M
LINK at end of Q3

→

4

Result

Every service sale = a LINK purchase on the market

≈$88M
reserve value

IN SHORT The Reserve is the only mechanism that turns company revenue into demand for the token

Launched Aug 7, 2025 as part of Chainlink Economics 2.0. Sources: Chainlink blog, The Block, Cryptoticker

Reserve: up 4× since the start of the year



IN SHORT The buyback pace has grown several times in a year — the best news for LINK holders

Weekly purchases: 80–90K LINK in late 2025 → 125–137K in 2026. 1,543,330 LINK bought in Q3. Sources: MEXC, KuCoin, Altcoinbuzz, Cryptoticker

Revenue: what is visible and what isn't

$59M

annualized onchain revenue (DefiLlama)

- **Visible:** onchain fees ≈$61.5M a year, revenue ≈$58.9M, almost all on Ethereum
- **Not visible:** bank and enterprise contracts. No amounts — only how much LINK the Reserve bought
- **Multiple:** market cap / onchain revenue ≈126×, FDV / revenue ≈165×
- **For reference:** ≈$34M of 2026 revenue went to the Reserve (Tokenomics.com)

IN SHORT Onchain revenue is about $59M a year. How much banks pay, Chainlink does not disclose

Multiples — QNN calculation from CoinGecko and DefiLlama data. Sources: DefiLlama, Tokenomics.com

LINK ETFs: access yes, money not much

FIRST

GLNK

Grayscale, since Dec 2, 2025. $37–41M inflow on day one, ~$64M in 48 hours. Fee 0.35%

10.03M
LINK as of Jun 30, 2026

SECOND

CLNK

Bitwise, since Jan 14, 2026. $2.59M on day one, fee 0.34%, custody — Coinbase

$5.18M
assets after day one

TOTAL

Combined

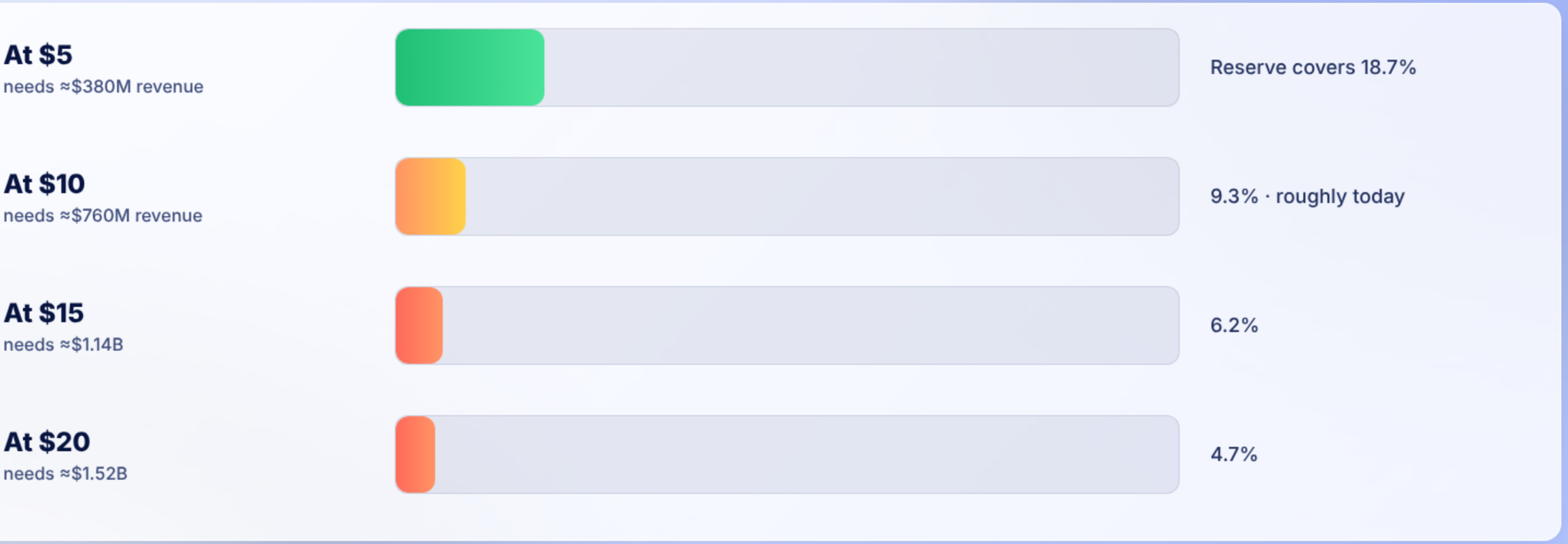
At end of Q3 both ETFs held 2.24% of market cap. In October there were five straight days of zero inflows

$230M+
AUM at end of Q3

IN SHORT ETFs gave institutions access to LINK, but there is no mass inflow yet

Both funds list staking as a future option. CME also launched LINK futures. Sources: Bitcoin.com (10-Q), BeInCrypto, Chainlink Q3, AlphaMaven

QNN math: when buybacks overtake unlocks



IN SHORT At today's price the Reserve covers ≈9% of unlocks. To break even, revenue must grow about 10×

Math: Reserve ≈1.54M LINK in Q3 at ~$11.5 ≈ $71M a year. Unlocks ≈76M LINK a year. The bar is the share of unlocks covered by buybacks. The lower the price, the more LINK the same dollar buys

QNN math: what funds Chainlink Labs

≈$560M

value of LINK sent to Binance per year (at $9.71)

- **Unlocks to the exchange:** ≈14.4M LINK per quarter, ≈57.6M a year
- **Onchain revenue:** ≈$59M a year — about 10× less
- **Conclusion:** a 600+ team and node payments are largely funded by tokens
- **Caveat:** public data doesn't show whether all of it is sold. Some may go OTC or to nodes

IN SHORT Unlocks aren't a hidden sale, they are the company budget. But holders should know who is selling

QNN calculation from unlock data (ChainCatcher, MEXC) and DefiLlama

QNN math: the “cliff” around 2029

~2029

when unallocated LINK runs out

- **Remaining:** 233M LINK with Chainlink Labs
- **Pace:** ~19M per quarter → enough for about 12 quarters
- **After that:** the main source of selling pressure disappears, the company must live on revenue
- **Risk:** the team can change the unlock pace either way — the schedule isn’t enforced in a contract

IN SHORT The most underrated catalyst: in ~3 years the team will have nothing left to sell

QNN calculation: (1B − 766.85M) / 19M per quarter ≈ 12.3 quarters

News vs price: six weeks of the best announcements



IN SHORT The best news of the year coincided with a 37% drop. Partnership news no longer moves the price

Points are dates with a confirmed price; the axis isn't to time scale. Sep 29 → Nov 14: −37.6%, while CCIP 2.0, Swift, Fulcrum, Link:NYC, Hanwha, Polymarket and Moody's were announced. Sources: Cryptoticker, BitRSS, CoinStats, CoinGecko

Incidents: what broke and who was at fault

May 29, 2025	**Euler, $500K**	The deUSD feed showed $1.03 and liquidations followed. Chaos Labs blamed Chainlink for a 25-minute delay; other experts said the oracle worked as designed
Feb 15, 2026	**Moonwell, $1.78M**	A misconfigured Chainlink OEV wrapper after vote MIP-X43: cbETH priced at ~$1 instead of $2,200
Mar 10, 2026	**Aave, ~$27M**	Aave's own wrapper (CAPO) underpriced wstETH by 2.85%. The Chainlink feed underneath worked correctly. Aave reimbursed 34 accounts
Always	**Multisig 4-of-9**	Feeds are upgradeable: 4 of 9 signatures can change any feed. The main argument of centralization critics

IN SHORT In the high-profile 2026 incidents, Chainlink feeds themselves worked correctly. Protocol add-ons broke

Sources: CryptoSlate, Yahoo Finance, rekt.news, Cointelegraph, Ackee

Competitors: where Chainlink is vulnerable

	Chainlink	Pyth	LayerZero
What it does	**Oracle + CCIP + CRE**	Price oracle	Cross-chain messaging
Model	**Push: price updates itself**	Pull: price is requested	Verifier network (DVN)
Strength	**Banks, lending protocols, reliability**	Speed, perps, Solana	~75% of messages, 130+ chains
Weakness	**Slower and more expensive**	TVS 11× smaller	Kelp hack, $4B+ outflow
Also	**RedStone — restaking**	Chronicle — MakerDAO	Wormhole, Axelar

IN SHORT In lending Chainlink is unrivaled. The fight is over speed, perps and cross-chain messaging

Sources: DefiLlama, Cointelegraph, BlockEden, KuCoin

Risks

TOKEN RISKS

Unlocks
~76M LINK a year, ≈10% of circulating supply, mostly to Binance

Loose link to the business
Clients don’t pay in LINK. Everything rests on the Reserve

Opaque revenue
Bank contracts aren’t disclosed

BUSINESS RISKS

Centralization
4-of-9 multisig and one company in charge

Competition
Pyth, RedStone, LayerZero and private bank networks

Slow banks
DTCC and Swift launches can slip by quarters

IN SHORT Business risks are modest. The main risks are in the token design

Sources: ChainCatcher, DefiLlama, Cointelegraph, Chainlink

Scenarios for the next 12–18 months

BEAR

$5–8

Altcoins fall, unlocks continue, DTCC and Swift delay launches. The Reserve only slows the decline

BASE

$9–15

Unlocks on schedule, the Reserve adds 1.5–2M LINK per quarter, banks go live gradually

BULL

$20+

Altseason, DTCC and Schwab live, Reserve revenue grows several times, staking extends to CCIP and ETFs

IN SHORT Scenarios aren’t a price forecast, they are conditions: what must happen for LINK to move one way or the other

Ranges are guideposts from price history: Aug 2024 low — $8.08, Sep 2026 peak — $15.56. Not financial advice

Catalysts: what to watch

DTCC — Q4 2026

Launch of the Tokenization Service and 24/7 collateral. First proof of major institutional revenue

Q4 report

≈late January 2027: how much LINK the Reserve bought, in dollars and in tokens

Next unlock

Expected around late December. Watch how much goes to Binance

Staking

Expansion to CCIP, a higher pool cap, staking inside ETFs

Charles Schwab

LINK trading going live for 40M accounts

Macro

Fed rates and the overall altcoin market: LINK moves with it

IN SHORT What matters in the coming months isn't new partners but numbers: Reserve revenue and the unlock schedule

Sources: Chainlink Q2 and Q3 2026, Link:NYC, ChainCatcher

Interesting facts

1. Chainlink serves 70%+ of all wrapped bitcoin after BitGo's move
2. Wallets holding ≥1M LINK grew from 100 to 125 in a year (Santiment)
3. Grayscale held LINK in a private trust since 2020 and turned it into an ETF only in 2025
4. CFTC Chairman Michael Selig spoke at Chainlink's conference in New York
5. Polymarket picked Chainlink as the official oracle for its 5- and 15-minute markets
6. The community staking pool filled within hours in December 2023
7. Wyoming FRNT is the first stablecoin from a US public entity with Proof of Reserve on Chainlink
8. Whoever first reports a feed failure gets 7,000 LINK

IN SHORT Chainlink wins where a mistake costs billions. Token holders get only part of that value

Sources: Chainlink Q3, MEXC (Santiment), Bitcoin.com, Link:NYC, Everstake, Chainlink Staking

Verdict: the best business, a token in question

1. Chainlink is crypto's #1 infrastructure: Swift, DTCC, J.P. Morgan and 70%+ of wrapped BTC
2. There is one link to the token — the Reserve. It is growing, but covers only ≈9% of unlocks
3. The main seller of LINK is the team itself: ≈57M LINK a year goes to Binance
4. The turning point is ~2029 when unlocks end, or earlier if revenue grows several times
5. Watch numbers, not partnerships: the Reserve, unlocks, DTCC

Not financial advice. This is an educational breakdown of public data. Crypto can lose all of its value — make your own decisions and only with money you can afford to lose.